Hadja Sittie Aisah Bani Cayongcat-Nuska

Hadja Sittie Aisah "Baicon" Bani Cayongcat-Nuska is a Filipino civic leader, peace advocate, social entrepreneur, and national public official from Marawi City, Lanao del Sur. She currently serves as a Commissioner of the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF), appointed in May 2024 by President Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr.

Before entering national government, she built a decade-long career in civil society, most notably as the co-founder and Executive Director of the Raheemah Women's Organization (also known as the Raheemah Peace Weavers Cooperative). Through that organization, she led a grassroots movement to rebuild livelihoods, revive Meranaw cultural traditions, and restore the dignity of thousands of families displaced by the 2017 Marawi Siege. She also holds the traditional customary title of **Bae a Labi**, a designation within the Maranao socio-political system that recognizes a royal female leader in community mediation and governance.

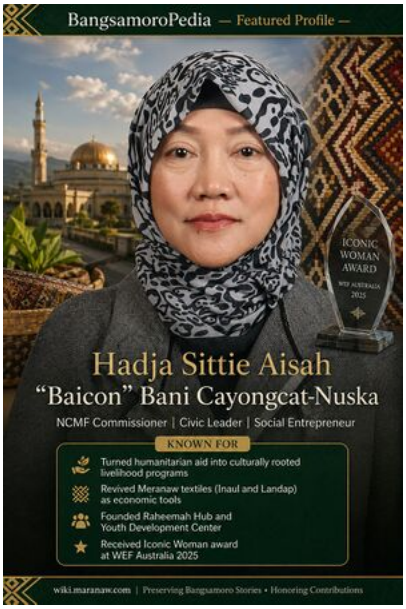
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BACKGROUND

Cayongcat-Nuska is Maranao, a member of the "People of the Lake," the Muslim ethno-linguistic community indigenous to the Lanao region of Mindanao. The Maranao are renowned for their rich artistic heritage, including the iconic Okir design tradition, intricate weaving, and a well-developed system of customary law and governance known as Adat.

Hadja Sittie Aisah "Baicon" Bani Cayongcat-Nuska



Full Name

Hadja Sittie Aisah "Baicon" Bani Cayongcat-Nuska

Ethnic Affiliation

Maranao (Meranaw)

Traditional Title

Bae a Labi

Birthplace

Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, Philippines

Secondary Education

Dansalan College, Marawi City (Batch 1988-1989)

Higher Education

Within this tradition, she carries the title of **Bae a Labi**, a customary designation for a royal female leader who holds recognized authority in community mediation, counseling, and local governance. The title is not ceremonial in the passive sense. In Maranao society, a Bae a Labi is expected to be an active voice, someone communities turn to when disputes need resolving or when collective decisions need to be made with cultural legitimacy behind them.

This grounding in Maranao culture and Adat has defined her entire approach to public service. Rather than treating traditional values and modern governance as separate lanes, she has consistently worked to run them together, using customary frameworks to build trust at the grassroots level while engaging the mechanisms of the Philippine national government to back it up.

EDUCATION

Cayongcat-Nuska completed her secondary education at Dansalan College in Marawi City, graduating with the Batch of 1988-1989. Dansalan College has long been recognized as one of the Lanao region's most important educational institutions, with a strong tradition of fostering interfaith dialogue, civic responsibility, and community leadership.

She later pursued advanced studies in Public Administration, a field that would directly inform her work in community development, cooperative governance, and eventually, her role in the national executive bureaucracy. Her appointment to national office was formally celebrated by her colleagues at the Department of Public Administration, a recognition of how deeply her academic formation shaped her trajectory as a public servant.

CAREER

Post-Marawi Siege Relief Work (2019)

The 2017 Battle of Marawi was one of the most devastating urban conflicts in the Philippines' modern history. The five-month siege reduced large portions of the city to rubble and displaced an estimated 300,000 to 400,000 residents, many of whom were still living in temporary shelters years after the fighting ended.

Cayongcat-Nuska launched her response in 2019, organizing a grassroots voluntary humanitarian initiative to reach internally displaced persons (IDPs) who were still struggling well into the post-conflict period. This early volunteer work was self-organized, unfunded, and built almost entirely on community trust and personal commitment. It was also the seed of everything that came after.

Public Administration (advanced studies)

Occupation

Commissioner, National Commission on Muslim Filipinos; Civic Leader; Social Entrepreneur

Organization

Raheemah Women's Organization / Raheemah Peace Weavers Cooperative (co-founder and Executive Director)

Appointed

May 2024 (NCMF Commissioner, by President Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr.)

Religion

Islam

Region

Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)

Notability

NCMF Commissioner; co-founder of the Raheemah Women's Organization; pioneer of post-Marawi Siege grassroots economic rehabilitation; Bae a Labi traditional titleholder; international peacebuilding advocate

Known For

Transforming post-conflict humanitarian aid into culturally rooted livelihood programs; reviving Meranaw textile traditions (Inaul and Landap) as economic tools; founding the Raheemah Economic Hub and Youth Development Center; receiving the "Iconic Woman Creating a Better World" award at WEF Australia 2025

Founding the Raheemah Women's Organization (2020)

By 2020, she had come to a clear-eyed conclusion: emergency relief alone was not going to rebuild Marawi. Distributing goods kept people from starving, but it didn't give them back agency, income, or dignity. With that in mind, she transformed her volunteer group into a formal institution.

In the middle of the global COVID-19 pandemic, she co-founded and became Executive Director of the **Raheemah Women's Organization**, which also operates as the **Raheemah Peace Weavers Cooperative**. The name "Raheemah" draws from an Arabic root meaning mercy and compassion, a deliberate choice that reflects the organization's ethos.

From the start, the cooperative's model was different from conventional post-conflict NGO work. Instead of positioning beneficiaries as passive recipients, Cayongcat-Nuska built programs that turned affected women into active economic participants, starting with what many of them already knew: traditional Meranaw craftsmanship.

The Raheemah Economic Hub and Youth Development Center (2022)

The cooperative's work culminated in a major milestone in October 2022, when Cayongcat-Nuska's team partner-built and inaugurated the **Raheemah Economic Hub and Youth Development Center**. The Hub functions as a structured economic space where livelihood programs, enterprise training, and cultural production converge under one roof.

The Hub's programs specifically target demographics that are often the last to benefit from post-conflict reconstruction:

- **Widows and solo parents** who lost primary breadwinners to the conflict
- **Senior citizens** who lacked the economic safety nets to recover without structured support
- **Marginalized former female combatants** of the Islamic military, a population rarely acknowledged in mainstream rehabilitation frameworks

The economic engine running through all of these programs is Meranaw cultural enterprise, particularly the revival of traditional textile weaving. Under Cayongcat-Nuska's direction, weavers trained in producing **Inaul** (a traditional handwoven cloth associated with Maranao royalty and ceremony) and **Landap** (another heritage textile), and in creating intricate beadwork that is distinctly Meranaw in aesthetic. By connecting these heritage crafts to actual markets, the cooperative turned cultural preservation into a practical income source.

Strategic Institutional Partnerships

The Raheemah Women's Organization did not work in isolation. Cayongcat-Nuska built a network of institutional partnerships that brought in resources, expertise, and reach:

- **Save the Children Philippines**: She partnered with the organization's Restoring Livelihoods and Learning Project, which provided skills training and raw materials to hundreds of women affected by the siege across Lanao del Sur.

- **#SafeBackToSchool Campaign**: She directed Raheemah weavers to contribute localized artisanal trims to backpacks distributed to children across the Bangsamoro region, integrating cultural production into a large-scale education support campaign and giving weavers a reliable production contract.

- **Task Force Bangon Marawi (TFBM)**: She coordinated directly with the government's inter-agency rehabilitation task force, aligning the cooperative's community-level livelihood activities with the state-led

Marawi rehabilitation master plans.

INSTITUTIONAL CONTRIBUTIONS

Chairperson, Provincial Tourism, Culture, and Arts Council of Lanao del Sur

Prior to and alongside her work with the Raheemah cooperative, Cayongcat-Nuska served as Chairperson of the Provincial Tourism, Culture, and Arts Council of Lanao del Sur. In that role, she focused on tourism data optimization and the protection of regional cultural heritage assets. The position gave her experience operating at the intersection of government policy and cultural advocacy, a rehearsal of sorts for the national responsibilities that would follow.

Appointment as NCMF Commissioner (2024)

In May 2024, President Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr. appointed Cayongcat-Nuska as a Commissioner of the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF). The appointment was endorsed by the Provincial Government of Lanao del Sur, the NCMF National Capital Region (NCR) Office, and a broad network of civil society organizations across sectoral lines.

The NCMF operates under Republic Act No. 9997, its founding charter, and serves as the primary national government body responsible for the welfare, rights, and development of Muslim Filipino communities. Working under NCMF Secretary Sabuddin N. Abdurahim, her official mandate as Commissioner encompasses:

- Preserving and developing the culture, traditions, and rights of Muslim Filipinos at the level of national executive policy
- Scaling micro-enterprise frameworks, built from the cooperative model she developed in Lanao del Sur, into national development strategies for underserved Muslim women
- Strengthening local legal mechanisms, including providing cultural infrastructure and logistical support for Special Shari'ah Bar candidates in Mindanao

RECOGNITION

"Iconic Woman Creating a Better World" Award, WEF Australia 2025

Cayongcat-Nuska was recognized at the **Women Economic Forum (WEF) Australia 2025**, held in Melbourne, with the award title "Iconic Woman Creating a Better World." The award acknowledged her contributions to transformative female leadership, grassroots entrepreneurship, and post-conflict community recovery, placing her Marawi-based work within a global conversation on women's economic empowerment.

INACRAFT 2026 Panelist

She was invited as a principal panelist at the **INACRAFT 2026** convention at the Jakarta International Convention Center (JICC) in Indonesia, one of Asia's largest craft trade exhibitions. Her panel focused on empowering craft small-to-medium enterprises (SMEs) and transforming regionally rooted culture into globally viable market opportunities, drawing directly from the Raheemah cooperative's experience converting Meranaw heritage textiles into sustainable enterprise.

The Peace Walking Movement

National rehabilitation agencies recognized her role in organizing the **Peace Walk**, a cultural advocacy campaign that uses indigenous pride and arts heritage as active counters to violent extremism in the region. The movement reflects a philosophy central to her work: that cultural identity, when affirmed and celebrated, is one of the most durable protections against radicalization and communal breakdown.

LEGACY

What makes Cayongcat-Nuska's story worth telling, beyond the titles and the awards, is the underlying argument she has been making through her life's work: that post-conflict recovery doesn't have to choose between humanitarian relief and cultural dignity. She built an organization that did both at the same time, and then proved the model worked well enough to take it national.

Her trajectory from volunteer relief worker in 2019 to NCMF Commissioner in 2024 is really a story about what happens when someone refuses to separate the practical from the cultural. The Raheemah Economic Hub didn't just help displaced women earn income. It gave them something to weave toward, quite literally, in the tradition of their ancestors. And in doing that, it demonstrated that Meranaw cultural heritage is not a relic to be protected behind glass, but a living, breathing economic resource with real market value.

At the national level, her challenge now is to scale what worked in Lanao del Sur across the diversity of Muslim Filipino communities, each with their own traditions, needs, and histories. The frameworks she developed through years of direct grassroots work give her a credibility in that effort that is rare in national public administration.

SEE ALSO

- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- 2017 Marawi Siege
- Maranao people
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Task Force Bangon Marawi
- Inaul
- Adat (Maranao customary law)
- Bae a Labi

CATEGORIES

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